proudly Indian; after all, these groups had been at the forefront of the freedom movement. However, their roots were firmly tied to their home provinces. This changed as the children of the middle class intermarried. Suddenly, there was a rapidly expanding group whose world view was essentially pan-Indian, their identity forged by the common experience of the housing colonies, the high-pressure education system, Bollywood films and cricket. We will return to this group later.

One of the unfortunate aspects of urban growth between the mid-fifties and the mid-eighties was the influence of ‘brutalist’ modernism. To socialists and fascists alike, the industrial starkness of reinforced concrete had a great attraction that is difficult to understand. Yet, the architects were somehow able to design buildings that are simultaneously unfriendly to the user, difficult to maintain and astonishingly ugly. Thus it came to be that India, land of the sublime symmetry of the Taj Mahal and the organic orchestra of Palitana, is also home to some of the ugliest buildings in the world. Every major city has them—Nehru Place and Inter-State Bus Terminal in Delhi, the Indian Express Building in Mumbai and the Haryana State Secretariat in Chandigarh.

Fascists and socialists have another thing in common—the urge to impose rigid master-plans on cities. In 1950, Prime Minister Nehru invited Le Corbusier, a French fascist, to design the new city of Chandigarh. Although the new city was to be built at the heart of ancient Sapta-Sindhu and very close to the Saraswati-Ghaggar, Corbusier was specifically asked by Nehru to create a city that was ‘unfettered’ by India’s ancient civilization. Enormous resources in land, material and money were poured into building the new city. At the same time, rigid master plans were imposed on existing cities. Delhi was master-planned in 1962 into strict zones according to use. However, the static master plan is to the city what socialist planning is to the economy. Both cities and economies are organic and rapidly evolving eco-systems. Just as the Mahalonobis model of central planning damaged the Indian economy, the country’s urban thinking was severely damaged by Le Corbusier’s philosophy that buildings were machines for living.